

“Stop underestimating Indian appliance buyers”

LIEBHERR INDIA’S SUCCESS MANTRA DECODED

“**E**arlier consumers were not willing to experiment,” according to Kapil Agarwal, Managing Director Sales at Liebherr India. “Earlier, Indian consumers would just go for the normal product which is available in the market, without being well aware of the product they’re buying before going to the shop floor.”

“But now consumers are well researched, they know the product, especially they know their problems for which they’re looking for precise solutions,” Agarwal says. And he’s right, if you think about it.

For years, Indian appliance buyers were fairly predictable in their buying habits. Give them a refrigerator that fits in their home / kitchen, with a recognizable brand on the door, add some festive discount for good measure, and that would be it. The only thing to discuss with the sales assistant was delivery schedules.

That buyer is fast disappearing, though. At the inaugural Digit India’s Top Appliance Awards 2026 which took place in New Delhi on August 7, Kapil Agarwal of Liebherr described a new breed of consumer who do their homework before walking into a store or shopping online for refrigerators or other appliances.

Indian consumers increasingly want solutions to their problems, not just products – and for appliances that means more than just saving kitchen space. According to Agarwal, today’s refrigerator buyers in India describe their food habits and expect the fridge in their homes to fit those needs.



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— KAPIL AGARWAL
Managing Director Sales
at Liebherr India

This revelation is forcing appliance manufacturers to stop thinking of Indian consumers as all being price-sensitive. “First of all, stop assuming that the Indian consumer is dumb. Also stop believing that the Indian consumer isn’t willing to pay a premium price. They want a good quality product and they are willing to pay for it,” notes Kapil Agarwal.

So is premiumisation the way to go? Not quite, if premium offerings means simply adding more features – with an AI sticker to boot – and magically expecting customers to follow. “Consumers really want the solution, not just a specific feature,” highlights Agarwal.

Liebherr, which won Most Innovative Double Door Refrigerator at DITAA 2026, offers an interesting example of how localisation can go beyond simply manufacturing in India. Agarwal pointed out the Indian practice of boiling milk before refrigeration – an alien concept in Europe – which required local consumer understanding and implementation in Liebherr’s refrigeration systems here.

There is a useful lesson here which Agarwal points out. How the next phase of India’s appliance market won’t be won by brands who overload their products with mindless features, but by companies that try to understand why a consumer needs any given feature to begin with.

This will ultimately force India’s appliance industry to become better, feels Agarwal. Where a more mature buyer will demand a more cohesive and a far more complete experience. ■